



Waiting to escape

South Vietnamese civilians hoping to be included in helicopter evacuation wait anxiously outside the US Embassy in Saigon on April 29, 1975. Many who believed they had been promised a flight to safety were in fact left behind.

Tragedy and chaos

The highly publicized Operation Babylift, which transported Vietnamese orphans to the United States, was interrupted by a tragic accident on April 4, when a Lockheed Galaxy transport aircraft crashed, killing many of the children on board. Meanwhile, many American personnel earmarked for evacuation refused to leave unless they could take Vietnamese dependents and friends with them. This led to a bureaucratic tussle that wasted more valuable time.

After the fall of Xuan Loc and the resignation of President Thieu on April 21, there was no longer any serious question of defending Saigon. Evacuation by fixed-wing aircraft continued at a more rapid pace, but without sufficient urgency, as some senior figures, including US Secretary of State Henry Kissinger and Ambassador Martin, did not believe that Saigon would be attacked.

■ **7,000** The approximate number of people evacuated from Saigon by helicopter on April 29–30, 1975.